

Supreme Court trials

Trial reenactments: *Plessy v. Ferguson* and *Brown v. Board of Education*

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1 Supreme Court trial reenactments

You will rank to be assigned to the *Plessy v. Ferguson* or *Brown v. Board of Education* trial groups. Working in these groups, you will research, prepare, and present a 45- to 60-minute reenactment for an audience. Each group will examine its case's historical context, legal claims, competing perspectives, and implications for equal access, diversity, democracy, educational opportunity, and justice.

2 Trial-group preparation

Trial-group discussion posts, archival research, and in-class preparation activities will help each group:

- Build historical context for the selected case.
- Locate and analyze primary sources, legal materials, archival documents, and historical news sources.
- Develop evidence-based arguments and identify competing legal and public perspectives.
- Connect historical events and artifacts to the group's case research.

- Prepare participant roles, debate points, documents, and other trial materials.
- Rehearse and refine the live reenactment.

Historical research connection

Use the class historical timeline and archival-research database to identify events, artifacts, sources, and educational themes relevant to your selected trial group. Entries may connect directly to *Plessy*, *Brown*, both cases, or broader historical contexts that help explain the legal and educational issues at stake.

3 Trial reenactment rubric

The Supreme Court trial reenactment component is worth **30 points** total.

Criterion	Strong evidence of achievement	Satisfactory evidence of achievement	Limited evidence of achievement	Points
Canvas discussion-board and group preparation	Consistently contributes substantive, timely, and constructive preparation work; advances group research, planning, and problem solving.	Participates in required preparation activities and contributes relevant work to the group.	Participation is inconsistent, late, minimal, or does not meaningfully support group preparation.	5

Criterion	Strong evidence of achievement	Satisfactory evidence of achievement	Limited evidence of achievement	Points
Group archival documents, legal annotations, and news sources	Group assembles a strong, accurate, and well-organized source set that includes relevant archival documents, legal materials, annotations, and historical news sources. Sources are clearly connected to the case and its historical and educational context.	Group assembles an adequate and generally accurate source set with relevant documents and some connection to case context.	Group source set is incomplete, weakly documented, inaccurate, or insufficiently connected to the case and its context.	5
Individual notes, debate points, and trial materials	Individual preparation is thorough, accurate, organized, and clearly grounded in historical and legal evidence. Notes, claims, questions, responses, and assigned materials demonstrate readiness for the group's reenactment.	Individual preparation is complete and generally accurate; materials demonstrate adequate readiness for the reenactment.	Individual preparation is incomplete, unclear, inaccurate, or not sufficiently connected to the group's evidence and assigned role.	10

Criterion	Strong evidence of achievement	Satisfactory evidence of achievement	Limited evidence of achievement	Points
Live in-class trial reenactment	Presentation is well prepared, historically and legally grounded, evidence-based, coherent, and engaging. Participants effectively communicate the case's competing perspectives and educational implications while fulfilling assigned roles.	Presentation is prepared and understandable, includes relevant historical/legal content, and fulfills most assigned roles and expectations.	Presentation is insufficiently prepared, difficult to follow, inaccurate, minimally evidence-based, or does not adequately fulfill assigned roles.	10
Total				30

4 What strong trial work demonstrates

Strong trial reenactment work does more than summarize a court case. It should demonstrate that the group can:

- Explain the historical conditions surrounding the case.
- Identify the legal question and relevant arguments.
- Use archival documents, primary sources, legal materials, and historical news sources as evidence.
- Represent competing perspectives fairly and accurately.
- Connect the case to schooling, educational access, citizenship, democracy, and social justice.
- Work collaboratively while being individually prepared for an assigned role.